in-law was one Peraisudia Pillai under whom B. Roche Victoria, connected with SSNCo and a defence witness in the VOC sedition case, worked as a clerk.[76] This list of shareholders shows that the Tuticorin traders were closely knit by caste, class, community and family ties. While they were overwhelmingly Vellalar, there was a sprinkling of Brahmins, Nadars and Paravars, as well as Christians and Muslims.

This also brings us to the curious case of K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, who did not take any shares, despite being a legal adviser and meddling in the affairs of the company, and constantly sniping at VOC (see Chapter 5).[77]

The pool of potential investors in Tuticorin was soon exhausted. Rs 10 lakh was too steep a capital to raise in a small port town. VOC soon stepped out of the confines of the district and began travelling the length and breadth of the presidency. His public talks, apart from garnering shares, contributed immensely to the politicization of the masses.

On 25 July, he addressed a meeting at a temple in Sirkazhi organized by K. Chidambaranatha Mudaliar, a local landlord and potentate. In this meeting, attended by 'local *mirasidars*, schoolmasters and vakils', VOC urged them to subscribe to the steamer service venture.[78] Probably sensing the potential at Sirkazhi, he stationed his trusted aide Parali S. Shanmugasundaram there for some months.[79] Evidently his efforts bore fruit. By the next year, K. Chidambaranatha Mudaliar had subscribed to enough shares to qualify him to be a director. By September 1907, three more persons from Sirkazhi, Thirunarayana Pillai, M.K.T. Muthuswami Chettiar and T.S. Kuppuswamy Pillai—it is likely that all of them were big landlords—had invested enough join as directors.[80] Curiously, the only two share certificates that have survived are those of shareholders from Sirkazhi: S. Saminatha Mudaliar and S. Nagalingam Pillai of Thadalankoil (see p. 404).

Arriving in Madurai towards the end of September, VOC gave a public talk, with Pandithurai Thevar in the chair, and defined Swadeshism as 'the development of Indian industries by Indians'.[81] He tactically underplayed the boycott aspect of the Swadeshi movement. It is likely that it was at this